ZTA Design Clinic Grading Guide

How to grade each team's work — the rubric, the proficiency levels, what a good answer looks like at each level, and a scoresheet. **Proctor only.** Use it alongside the **ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide**, which holds the reference answers.

How to use this guide. This is the "how to grade" companion to the Solution Guide (the "answers"). For each use case, read the team's work, score three criteria against the rubric, total to a level, and give feedback. The proficiency levels below are a facilitation framework — calibrate them with your SME before the event.

How grading works

Each use case is scored out of **100 points**, split across three criteria:

- **Mapping — 40 pts:** how well the design addresses the customer's pain points and requirements.
- **Products — 30 pts:** the right Cisco products, with how they work and why they were chosen.
- **Diagram — 30 pts:** the clarity and correctness of the proposed design.

The total maps to an overall **level**. Use cases 1–3 are required; 4–5 are bonus.

Expert
90–100
Complete and defensible. Every pain point and requirement mapped, right products, and clear Cisco differentiators.

Professional
75–89
Solid, correct design. Right products with correct integrations; nearly every requirement addressed.

Associate
60–74
Meets the basics. Names the right products for most pains, with a workable diagram.

Developing
below 60
Incomplete or off-target. Key pains or requirements unaddressed.

The rubric

Score each criterion independently using the band that best fits, then add the three scores.

Mapping / 40 pts

How well the design addresses the customer's pain points and requirements.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	36–40	Every pain point and requirement is mapped explicitly and correctly, with sound reasoning.
Professional	30–35	Nearly all pain points and requirements are addressed with correct, specific responses.
Associate	24–29	Most pain points are addressed; some requirements are vague or missing.
Developing	0–23	Misreads the scenario; few pain points or requirements are addressed.

Products / 30 pts

The right Cisco products, with how they work and why they were chosen.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	27–30	Correct products with clear Cisco differentiators (why Cisco wins), including advanced or bonus capabilities.
Professional	23–26	Correct products with correct integrations; explains how each one works.
Associate	18–22	Names the main products and what they do, but says little about why.
Developing	0–17	Wrong or missing products; cannot explain how they work.

Diagram / 30 pts

The clarity and correctness of the proposed network design.

LEVEL	POINTS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Expert	27–30	Clear, complete diagram; shows enforcement points, integrations, and how it extends the cumulative design.
Professional	23–26	Accurate diagram showing the main components and traffic flows for this use case.
Associate	18–22	Basic diagram; key elements are present but incomplete or unclear.
Developing	0–17	No diagram, or one that doesn’t reflect the proposed design.

How to grade a team — step by step

1. **Read the team’s work.** Read the team’s diagram and their three answer areas — pain points, requirements and products — for the use case. Compare them against the reference answer in the ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide.
2. **Score each criterion.** Using the rubric, score Mapping (out of 40), Products (out of 30) and Diagram (out of 30) independently. Pick the point range for the band that best fits.
3. **Total and set the level.** Add the three scores for a total out of 100, then read the overall level: Expert 90–100, Professional 75–89, Associate 60–74, Developing below 60.
4. **Give feedback.** Write two things the team did well and two things to improve. Be specific — point to the exact pain point, product or diagram element.
5. **Repeat per use case.** Score use cases 1–3 for every team. Score 4–5 only if the team attempted them (bonus).

Grading principles

- Grade against the reference answer, not one exact wording — reward valid alternative designs that still meet the requirements.
- Award partial credit generously. The goal is learning and better customer conversations, not gatekeeping.
- Reward articulation of Cisco differentiators — explaining why Cisco wins is the core SE skill this clinic builds.

- Score the three criteria independently before totalling, so a strong diagram doesn't mask weak product reasoning (or the reverse).
- Use cases 1–3 are required; 4–5 are bonus. Apply the same rubric to all five.
- For the key points to reward on each use case, see the "Proctor — what to reward" note in the Solution Guide.

> **Calibrate first.** Before the event, have all proctors score the same sample answer together and compare results. Align on what an Associate, Professional and Expert answer looks like so scoring is consistent from table to table. Aim to grade in a few minutes per use case.

What a good answer looks like — by level

Use these as calibration anchors. They describe a typical answer at each level; award the level whose description best matches, and use the rubric point ranges for the exact score. Each use case also lists **SME verification questions** (from the SME Cheat Sheet) to test real understanding — a team that only name-drops products but can't answer these is not yet at Expert. Full reference answers are in the Solution Guide.

Use Case #1 — Managed Environment; Segmentation Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Uses ISE to authenticate users and proposes group-based segmentation for Employees, IoT, deskagents and Guest; a workable campus/branch diagram. May still rely on VLANs or omit Posture and the PCI angle.
Professional	Uses SGTs instead of VLAN/IP subnets; ISE authenticates and profiles (802.1X / MAB / WebAuth) and assigns an SGT per group; the SGT Matrix enforces IoT, Guest and Mac-mini access; ISE Posture remediates out-of-date PCs. Diagram shows ISE and SGT enforcement across campus, branch and the data center.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: SGTs are topology-independent and extend end-to-end into multicloud data centers, segmentation needs no new firewalls (the budget pain), and SGACLs are more efficient than IP ACLs. Adds pxGrid Rapid Threat Containment and Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping, and ties each response to a specific pain or requirement.

> **SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS**
> - Did the group use SGTs correctly — and do they understand dynamic vs. static SGT assignment?
> - Do they understand how ISE profiling works, and how ISE Posture checks AV/OS (real-time vs. continuous)?
> - Can they explain SGT Matrix operations for the group-to-group rules (IoT, Guest, Mac-mini)?
> - Do they recognise that SGTs alone may not satisfy PCI where L7 inspection is required?
> - Can they explain SGACL efficiency, pxGrid / Rapid Threat Containment, and Secure Workload?

Use Case #2 — Remote Worker: Zero Trust Access Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes Cisco Secure Access / ZTNA for remote access and Duo for identity, with a basic SASE idea. May miss clientless RDP for contractors or the Secure Web Gateway specifics.

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Professional	Uses the Zero Trust Access module for per-application access (full VPN only for legacy apps); Secure Web Gateway blocks gambling and gaming; contractors get clientless browser access; Duo Passport for SSO; Duo Directory replaces the costly Okta IdP; SD-WAN integrates with Secure Access for SASE. Diagram shows the Secure Client modules through Secure Access to apps and branches.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: least-privilege ZTA versus over-permissive VPN, Duo Passport OS-level SSO, passwordless to end credential theft, VPN traffic mapped to an SGT for segmentation, and a single unified policy. Every pain point and requirement is mapped.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Can they explain the difference between ZTNA and full-client VPN — and when to position each?
- Do they understand how the Secure Web Gateway blocks the gambling/gaming categories?
- Can they explain Duo SSO / Passport and passwordless, and why Duo IdP beats Okta on cost and security?
- Can they explain Cisco SASE (Secure Access + Catalyst SD-WAN) and its advantages?
- Why is clientless RDP a common contractor ask, and what are the risks?

Use Case #3 — AI Access and Agent Controls Required

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Recognises the need to control AI usage and proposes Secure Access AI Access and/or Duo with basic guardrails. May miss the MCP-server and desktop-agent controls.
Professional	Uses AI Access for shadow-AI visibility and guardrails; the AI Gateway to register and govern MCP servers; Secure Client with agentic client discovery to control desktop agents; tenant control for the corporate ChatGPT tenant; and Duo IdP with agent registration (DCR). Addresses all four pain points.
Expert	All of the above, plus semantic inspection to block risky models, fine-grained per-tool authorization via the Duo / Secure Access MCP integration, and the Secure Access DLP + Cisco AI Defense story — and explains why Duo IdP is the easiest AI Gateway integration.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand the AI Gateway architecture and what MCP is?
- Do they understand Secure Access tenant control for the corporate ChatGPT tenant?
- Do they understand the value of Duo IdP — agent registration (DCR) and OAuth for MCP services?
- Do they understand the risks of public AI models and how semantic inspection helps?

Use Case #4 — Merger / Acquisition; Extend Segmentation Bonus

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes extending segmentation to the acquired site using FTD and using Duo for the acquired users. A basic, workable idea.
Professional	Uses FTD inline SGT tagging over a site-to-site tunnel to extend TrustSec; Duo Directory via SCIM to host the 100 users without full onboarding; Duo SSO routing for Okta coexistence; source/destination SGTs to restrict access to Site 9951; and Duo passwordless for the breached users.

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: Cisco's inline SGT-tagging advantage, Security Cloud Control (SCC) to push unified SGT policy into SD-WAN, minimal authentication disruption during transition, and phishing-resistant passwordless. All pains and requirements mapped.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand FTD inline SGT tagging to extend TrustSec, and source/destination SGT policy?
- Do they understand Duo Directory and importing users from Okta via SCIM?
- Do they understand Duo SSO routing for Okta coexistence, and passwordless for the breached users?
- Can they explain how SCC provides unified SGT policy management?

Use Case #5 — Zero Trust across multicloud Data Centers Bonus

LEVEL	WHAT A TEAM AT THIS LEVEL TYPICALLY PRODUCES
Associate	Proposes Cisco Secure Workload for visibility and segmentation across the clouds. A basic idea that may miss Kubernetes and runtime protection.
Professional	Uses Secure Workload App Dependency Mapping for discovery and auto-baseline microsegmentation across on-prem, AWS and Azure; Isovalent (Cilium / eBPF / Tetragon) for Kubernetes; Security Cloud Control (SCC) to unify consoles; and ISE common policy shared via pxGrid. Addresses budget, native-features and complexity.
Expert	All of the above, plus the differentiators: one end-to-end policy across ISE, Secure Workload and FTD via pxGrid, kernel-level eBPF protection, compensating controls (segmentation + runtime protection) for unpatchable IoT, and CSW–FTDv sync for virtual appliances. Complete mapping.

SME VERIFICATION QUESTIONS

- Do they understand Secure Workload — agent/agentless, App Dependency Mapping, auto-baseline policy?
- Do they understand CSW + FTD integration, and CSW–FTDv policy sync for virtual appliances?
- Do they understand Isovalent (Cilium / eBPF / Tetragon) for Kubernetes and runtime protection?
- Do they understand ISE common policy via pxGrid for end-to-end, and SCC to unify consoles?

Team scoresheet

Team / table #: ___________________________

USE CASE	MAPPING /40	PRODUCTS /30	DIAGRAM /30	TOTAL /100	LEVEL
UC1					
UC2					
UC3					
UC4 (bonus)					
UC5 (bonus)					

Overall — what the team did well	Overall — where they can improve

Acronyms (SGT, ISE, ZTNA, SASE, SWG, MCP, DCR, CSW, pxGrid, eBPF…) are defined in the **glossary of the ZTA Design Clinic Solution Guide**.